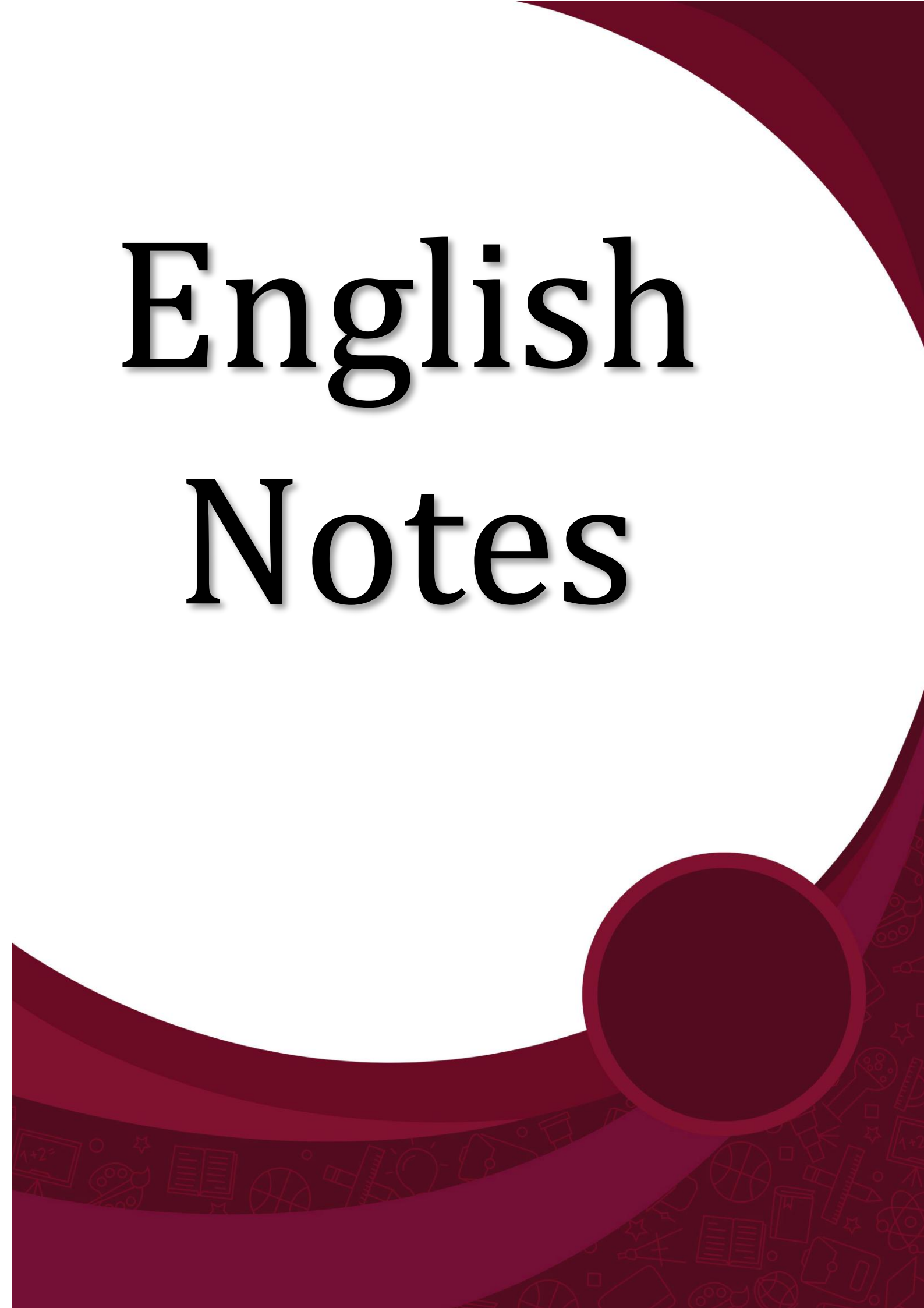


English Notes



Flamingo Chapter-3

Deep Water

About the Author – William O. Douglas

William O. Douglas was an American judge and a member of the U.S. Supreme Court. In this autobiographical extract, he narrates how he overcame his deep fear of water through courage, determination, and systematic effort.

Introduction

Deep Water is an autobiographical account that highlights how childhood fears can deeply affect a person's life. The story shows how terrifying experiences can create long-lasting phobias. However, it also teaches that **fear can be conquered through determination, courage, and persistent effort.**

The chapter conveys a powerful message:

Fear is temporary, but courage and willpower can defeat it.

Theme of the Chapter

The story focuses on:

- Fear and phobia
- Childhood trauma
- Determination and courage
- Power of will
- Overcoming challenges
- Psychological struggle
- Victory over fear

Summary of Deep Water

Early Fear of Water

Since childhood, Douglas wanted to learn swimming. However, at the age of three or four, he was knocked down and buried by a powerful wave at a beach in California. This frightening experience created a deep fear of water in his mind.

Despite this fear, at the age of ten or eleven, he decided to learn swimming at the YMCA pool, believing it to be safe because it had a shallow end.

The Misadventure at YMCA

One day, while sitting alone at the YMCA pool, a big boy suddenly picked him up and threw him into the deep end of the pool.

Douglas sank to the bottom of the pool. He swallowed water and felt terrified. While going down, he planned to push himself up with a strong jump. However, he came up slowly and could not shout for help.

He went down a second time and again tried to rise, but it was useless. Terror gripped him completely.

During the third attempt, instead of air, he swallowed water. His body became weak. The light seemed to fade, and panic slowly gave way to unconsciousness. He stopped struggling and sank into oblivion.

When he regained consciousness, he found himself lying beside the pool, vomiting water.

Aftermath of the Incident

This traumatic incident left Douglas with a deep fear of water. The fear followed him everywhere and deprived him of the joys of:

- Swimming
- Canoeing
- Boating
- Fishing

Water became a symbol of terror for him.

Overcoming the Fear

Determined not to let fear control his life, Douglas hired a professional instructor to teach him swimming.

The instructor taught him step-by-step:

- Breathing techniques
- Floating
- Leg movements
- Arm strokes

Gradually, Douglas gained confidence. However, small traces of fear still remained.

To completely conquer his fear, he challenged himself by swimming in different lakes. Finally, while swimming across Warm Lake, he realised that his fear had disappeared.

Climax and Realisation

Douglas understood an important truth:

“In death there is peace. There is terror only in the fear of death.”

He realised that the **will to live is stronger than the fear of death**. Once fear is confronted, it loses its power.

Title Justification

The title *Deep Water* symbolises:

- The literal deep end of the pool
- The depth of fear
- Psychological struggle
- The journey from fear to confidence

It represents both physical and emotional challenges.

Message of the Chapter

The story teaches:

- Fear can be overcome with determination
- One must face fears instead of running away
- Courage builds confidence
- Strong willpower can defeat any obstacle
- Trauma can be healed with effort

Character Sketch of William O. Douglas

- Determined
- Courageous
- Sensitive
- Strong-willed
- Persistent
- Self-reflective

He transforms from a frightened child into a confident adult through perseverance.

Detailed Summary

The story talks about how the terrifying memories of the childhood haunt even the adult mind and the shadow of these frightening experiences continue to lurk in the mind and rob one of all the confidences. It is imperative to make deliberate planned efforts to get over that fear which otherwise can lead to a lifelong complex.

William O. Douglas had a desire to learn swimming since childhood. At the age of three or four, he was knocked down and buried by a wave at a beach in California. He developed a great aversion to water. At the age of ten or eleven he decided to learn to swim with water wings at the Y.M.C.A pool since it was safe at the shallow end.

A MISADVENTURE:

while sitting alone and waiting for others to come at the Y.M.C.A pool, a big boy came and

threw Douglas into deep end of the pool. Douglas swallowed water and went straight down to the bottom of the pool. While going down he planned to make a big jump upwards but came up slowly. Stark terror seized him.

Tried to shout but could not.....As he went down the pool for the second time, he tried to jump upwards but it was sheer waste of energy. Terror held him deeper and deeper. During the third trial, he sucked water instead of air.

Light was going out and there was no more panic. So, he ceased all efforts and he became unconscious. He crossed to oblivion. When revived, he found himself vomiting beside the pool. He was in the grip of fear of water and it deprived him of the joys of canoeing, boating, swimming and fishing. Later, to overcome his phobia for water, he hired an instructor to learn swimming.

The instructor taught him swimming piece by piece. He went to different lakes to swim and found tiny vestiges of fear still gripped him. He challenged the fear and swam. Swimming up and down the Warm Lake he finally overcame his fear of water. He realized that in death there is peace and there is terror only in fear of death. Will to live is stronger than fear of death.

- William O. Douglas had a desire to learn swimming since childhood.
- At the age of three or four, he was knocked down and buried by a wave at a beach in California.
- He developed a great aversion to water.
- At the age of ten or eleven he decided to learn to swim with water wings at the Y.M.C.A pool since it was safe at the shallow end.
- **A misadventure:-** while sitting alone and waiting for others to come at the Y.M.C.A pool, a big boy came and threw Douglas into deep end of the pool.
- Douglas swallowed water and went straight down to the bottom of the pool.
- While going down he planned to make a big jump upwards but came up slowly.
- Stark terror seized him.
- Tried to shout but could not.....
- As he went down the pool second time, he tried to jump upwards but it was a waste of energy.
- Terror held him deeper and deeper.
- During the third trial he sucked water instead of air.
- Light was going out and there was no more panic.

- So he ceased all efforts and he became unconscious.
- He crossed to oblivion.
- When revived he found himself vomiting beside the pool.
- He was in grip of fear of water and it deprived him of the joys of canoeing, boating swimming and fishing.
- Hired an instructor to learn swimming.
- The instructor taught him swimming piece by piece.
- He went to different lakes to swim and found tiny vestiges of fear still gripped him.
- He challenged the fear and swam.
- Swimming up and down the Warm Lake he finally overcame his fear of water.
- He realized that in death there is peace and there is terror only in fear of death.
- Will to live is stronger than fear of death.

Important Points for Revision

- ✓ Childhood trauma created fear
- ✓ Misadventure at YMCA intensified phobia
- ✓ Fear deprived him of happiness
- ✓ Systematic training helped him recover
- ✓ Willpower defeated fear

Important Questions

Short Answer Questions

1. What childhood incident created fear of water in Douglas?
2. What happened at the YMCA pool?
3. Why could Douglas not shout for help?
4. How did the instructor help him?
5. What did Douglas realise at the end?

Long Answer Questions

1. Describe the misadventure at the YMCA pool.
2. How did Douglas overcome his fear of water?
3. What message does *Deep Water* convey about fear?

Exam Writing Tips

- ✓ Use keywords like trauma, phobia, determination, willpower
- ✓ Explain psychological struggle clearly
- ✓ Mention three attempts to rise from water
- ✓ Add final realisation quote
- ✓ Write structured answers with introduction and conclusion

